

Excelsior, the lone warrior

By C.G.S.Narayanan

The pawn, the humblest of all chessmen, is the most potent force when it reaches lucrative eighth rank to promote. In excelsior a pawn on its original square travels to promote. It is not very often that the pawn can wend its way through to the promoting square all on its own in a direct mate problem. The ingenious and the most famous excelsior is the direct mate in five by the American chess problem wizard, Sam Loyd, who once asked his friend that in the position given below as to which white piece has least chance of making the key. Who can guess that the innocuous white pawn at b2 would be delivering a fatal blow with a promotion on a8! After the key 1.b4 white rook threatens mate on the base rank via Rd5 or Rf5.

The defence Rc5+ is met by bxc5 the pawn jumping to the next rank. Now the white pawn sets up another threat Rb1 which black defends by 2...a2. The juggernaut rolls on with 3.Rc6. The defence Bc7 tries to delay the eventual 4.cxb7 is yet another climb closer to the peak and the final assault bxa8=Q is unavoidable. Before black could take notice of the lurking movement of WP it has advanced menacingly to promote.

Samuel Loyd

Second prize, Set. Paris Ty 1861



Mate in five moves

Solution: **1.b4** (2.Rd5/Rf5 3.Rf1 or Rd1) Rc5+ 2.bxc5(3.Rb1) a2 3.c6 Bc7 4.cxb7 and 5.bxa8Q mate(1...2.Rf5 Bc7/Bg5 2.Rf5; 1...Rc6 2.Rd5; 1...Rc4 2.Rf5 and 1...Rc2 2.Nxc2). Loyd's own comment on this masterpiece was "It was composed in a spirit of fun and is a joke from beginning to end". (Source: Sam Loyd and his chess problems (A C White))

Two excelsiors for solving

Wormald Robert

Illustrated London News 1857

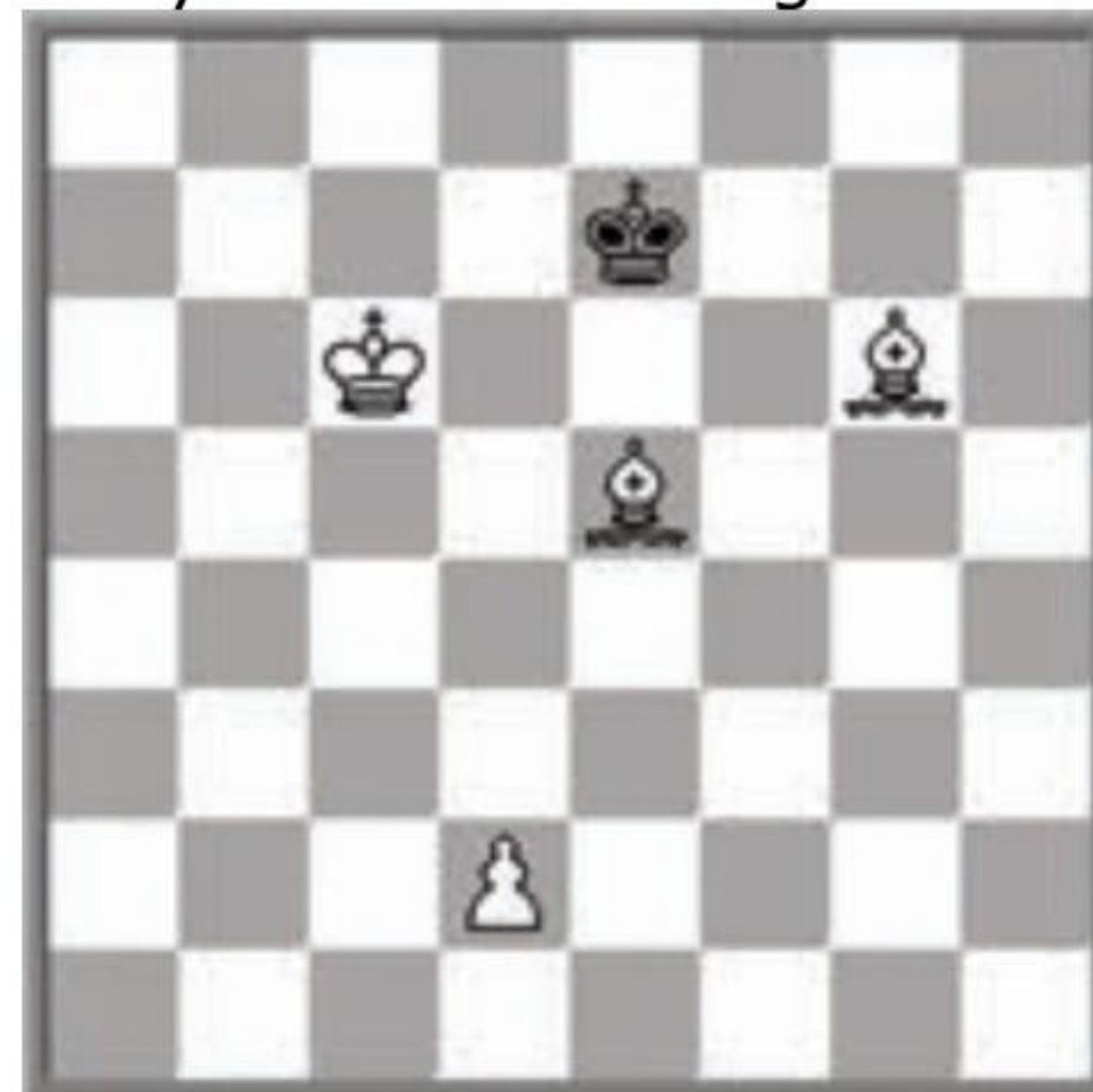


Mate in five moves

A **slowed-down excelsior** which starts with a pawn's single-step advance thus taking him one move more to reach the promotion rank.

Shinkman W.A

Bayurenumwandings 1907



Mate in six moves

Solution to problem for solving in the article 'Patterns in problems'(CGSN)
Try 1.Ra3? waiting 1...Kb4 2.Qxb3(A) 1...c2 2.Nd6(B) 1..N any 2.Rxd4(C)
But 1...Nd2! **Key 1.Qb1! waiting** 1...Kb4 2.Rxd4(C); 1...c2 2.Qxb3 (A) 1...N any 2.Nd6(B); 1...Bb4 2.Nxb6

Readers may send in their queries to
cgsnarayanan@hotmail.com